

No-three-in-line configurations with exact half-turn symmetry for $n = 36, 37, 39$, and a balance lemma for symmetric defects

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with two autonomous Claude agents (Anthropic) — see the authorship statement in Section 6

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Abstract

We report $2n$ -point no-three-in-line configurations on the $n \times n$ grid whose symmetry group is exactly the half-turn $\{1, \rho^2\}$, for $n = 36, 37$ (two inequivalent configurations) and 39. For these sizes Flammenkamp’s database (state 2026-08-11) listed no configuration in that class; a further such configuration is given for $n = 33$. The configurations were found by *exhaustive* branch-and-bound searches over small structured sub-classes of the half-turn class: quarter-turn-symmetric configurations with a controlled “defect” consisting of a few half-turn pairs. A simple *balance lemma* restricts the admissible defects to Eulerian digraphs on the row classes $\{i, n - 1 - i\}$; the smallest defects are one diagonal loop (Flammenkamp’s pseudo-class *rct4*), a directed 3-cycle of pairs (odd n) and one loop on each long diagonal (even n). We give exhaustive counts of these families for small n , describe the solver and its validation against the known counts (OEIS A000769 and the class counts of the database), report measured growth rates of the search cost, and record negative results (empty families, failure of warm starts). Code, logs and configurations are available.

1 Introduction

The no-three-in-line problem (Dudeney, 1917) asks for the largest set of points of the $n \times n$ grid $\{0, \dots, n - 1\}^2$ containing no three collinear points. Since a line parallel to an axis contains at most two points, at most $2n$ points can be placed, and $2n$ -point configurations are the objects of interest. Their existence for every n is a well-known open problem; a probabilistic heuristic (Guy–Kelly, corrected form) suggests that for large n fewer than $2n$ points can be placed. Computationally, $2n$ -point configurations were known for all $n \leq 46$ and for $n = 48, 50, 52$ for decades [1, 2]; in 2025–2026 constraint programming [4], GPU branch-and-bound and SAT solving extended this to all $n \leq 70$ and to $n = 72, 74, 76$ (see the database [3], which also records, for each n , the number of configurations by their exact symmetry class under the dihedral group D_4 of the square, and marks the cells for which no configuration is known).

This note concerns those cells rather than the record sizes. Flammenkamp’s table lists, for each n , the number of inequivalent $2n$ -point configurations whose stabilizer in D_4 is exactly a given subgroup: trivial (*iden*), the half-turn (*rot2*), one diagonal reflection (*dia1*), one axis reflection (*ort1*), the quarter turns (*rot4*), both diagonal reflections (*dia2*), both axis reflections (*ort2*) and the full group (*full*), plus the pseudo-class *rct4* $\subset$ *rot2* (“rot4 symmetry except on the long diagonals”). As of 2026-08-11 the *rot2* column was complete for $n \leq 31$ and empty (no configuration known) for $n = 36, 37, 39, 41, 45, 47, \dots$

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Results. (i) A balance lemma (Section 2) describing which “defects” a half-turn-symmetric configuration may have relative to a larger subgroup $H \leq D_4$: the defect pairs must form an Eulerian digraph on the row classes. In particular a single half-turn pair must lie on a long diagonal (which explains why `rct4` is the only one-pair pseudo-class), and the smallest larger defects are a directed 3-cycle of pairs (odd n) and one loop on each diagonal (even n). (ii) Exhaustive enumerations of these families for small n (Section 4); several of them are non-empty exactly where the pure classes are rare. (iii) The first known configurations with exact `rot2` symmetry for $n = 36$ (two-loop family), $n = 37$ (3-cycle family, two inequivalent configurations) and $n = 39$ (3-cycle family), and a further one for $n = 33$; the configurations are listed in the Appendix and were verified twice by independent programs. (iv) A description of the exact solver and its validation, growth measurements for the cost of finding one $2n$ -point configuration in the classes `rot4`, `rct4` and `rot2`, and a list of negative results.

2 Symmetry classes and the balance lemma

Let $m = n - 1$ and let D_4 act on the grid; write $\rho(u, v) = (v, m - u)$ for the quarter turn, so $\rho^2(u, v) = (m - u, m - v)$, $\sigma(u, v) = (v, u)$ for the reflection in the main diagonal and $\sigma'(u, v) = (m - v, m - u)$ for the reflection in the anti-diagonal. A $2n$ -point no-three-in-line configuration has exactly two points in every row and every column.

Fix a subgroup $H \leq D_4$ containing ρ^2 and consider a `rot2`-symmetric configuration C (i.e. $\rho^2 C = C$) which is a disjoint union of H -orbits and of a set D of half-turn pairs $\{p, \rho^2 p\}$ (the *defect*) that are not H -orbits. For $a \in \{0, \dots, m\}$ let $r_X(a)$, $c_X(a)$ denote the numbers of points of a set X in row a and in column a .

Lemma 1 (balance). *If H contains a motion mapping column a onto row a for every a (any quarter turn or any diagonal reflection does), then every H -orbit O satisfies $r_O(a) = c_O(a)$ for all a . Consequently the defect of a $2n$ -point configuration satisfies $r_D(a) = c_D(a)$ for all a .*

Proof. If $g \in H$ maps column a onto row a then g maps $O \cap \{\text{column } a\}$ bijectively onto $O \cap \{\text{row } a\}$ because $gO = O$; hence $r_O(a) = c_O(a)$. Summing over the orbits and using $r_C(a) = c_C(a) = 2$ gives $r_D(a) = c_D(a)$. $\square$

Interpret the pairs of D as arcs of a digraph on the row classes $\{i, m - i\}$: the pair $\{(x, y), (m - x, m - y)\}$ occupies rows $x, m - x$ and columns $y, m - y$, i.e. it is an arc from class $\bar{x}$ to class $\bar{y}$ (a loop if $\bar{x} = \bar{y}$, i.e. if the pair lies on a long diagonal). Lemma 1 says that in-degree equals out-degree at every class:

Corollary 2. *The defect D is an Eulerian digraph on the row classes, hence a union of directed cycles. A single defect pair must be a loop, i.e. must lie on a long diagonal. For $H = \langle \rho \rangle$ every usable H -orbit has four points (the centre cell, a fixed point for odd n , cannot occur), so $2n = 4a + 2|D|$ and $|D| \equiv n \pmod{2}$: for odd n the smallest defects are one loop — this is exactly the pseudo-class `rct4` of [3] — and a directed 3-cycle $(x, y), (y, z), (z, x')$ with $x' \in \{x, m - x\}$; for even n the smallest defects are two loops. (For $H = \langle \sigma, \sigma' \rangle$ the diagonal 2-orbits $\{(i, i), (m - i, m - i)\}$ are themselves H -orbits, and the parity condition counts them together with D .)*

For $H = \langle \rho \rangle$ (`rot4`) an H -orbit off the diagonals is $\{(u, v), (v, m - u), (m - u, m - v), (m - v, u)\}$; for $H = \langle \sigma, \sigma' \rangle$ (`dia2`) it is $\{(u, v), (v, u), (m - u, m - v), (m - v, m - u)\}$. We call these the C4 base and the V2 base. The following families are therefore the natural next steps beyond `rct4`:

- **3-cycle family** (odd n): $(n - 3)/2$ orbits of the C4 base (or of the V2 base) plus a directed 3-cycle of half-turn pairs;

- **two-loop family** (even n): $n/2 - 1$ orbits of the C4 base plus one loop on each long diagonal, $\{(x, x), (m - x, m - x)\}$ and $\{(y, m - y), (m - y, y)\}$ with $y \notin \{x, m - x\}$ (for $y \in \{x, m - x\}$ the two loops form a rot4-orbit and the configuration is rot4-symmetric).

A configuration of these families is not H -symmetric (the defect breaks H), so its stabilizer is a proper subgroup of H containing ρ^2 ; in every case found below the stabilizer is exactly $\{1, \rho^2\}$ (verified explicitly), so the configurations fall into the rot2 column of the database. A two-loop configuration is “rot4 symmetric except on the long diagonals”, i.e. of rct4 type for even n (the database keeps rct4 as a pseudo-class for odd n only).

Remark 3. The families of “mixed bases” — C4-orbits together with at least one V2-orbit (plus one loop for odd n) — are admissible by Lemma 1 but turned out to be empty in all our enumerations (all $n \leq 23$ exhaustively, and randomized searches up to $n = 33$); we have no structural explanation.

3 The solver

All searches were done with an exact branch-and-bound program (**there.c**, about 600 lines of C, no external libraries). Cells are $t = un + v$; a state keeps two bit-matrices, *alive* by rows and by columns. Every pair of chosen points “shades” all grid cells of the line through them (walked with the primitive direction obtained from a gcd table); shaded cells die, as do all cells of a row or column that already holds two points. A symmetry class is imposed by choosing whole orbits: a cell is a candidate only if its whole orbit is alive, and the “orbit-alive” bit-masks are derived from the alive matrices by transposition and bit reversal (one word operation per group element). Branching uses the most constrained reading class (row or column with the fewest orbit-alive cells) and dies as soon as some class cannot be completed. A failed candidate is killed for its siblings, so that a search with a fixed symmetry class is complete: “no configuration” is a proof of absence for that class. With restarts and randomized tie-breaking the same program is used to find one configuration quickly. A **PAIRS** option fixes a set of half-turn pairs (the defect), kills their images under the base group, and searches the remaining orbits of the base; the same option with a diagonal pair reproduces rct4 exactly.

Validation. For $n \leq 10$ the program enumerates all $2n$ -point configurations without symmetry: 1, 2, 11, 32, 50, 132, 380, 368, 1135 labelled configurations for $n = 2, \dots, 10$, which reduce to 1, 1, 4, 5, 11, 22, 57, 51, 156 classes under D_4 , in agreement with OEIS A000769. For symmetric classes we compared the number N_H of labelled configurations invariant under H with the class counts c_K of [3] through $N_H = \sum_{K \supseteq H} c_K \cdot |D_4|/|K|$: e.g. rot2 for $n = 8$: $36 = 4 \cdot 7 + 2 \cdot 4$; $n = 10$: $67 = 4 \cdot 13 + 2 \cdot 6 + 2 \cdot 1 + 1$; dial for $n = 13$: $20 = 2 \cdot 9 + 2 \cdot 1$; $n = 15$: $28 = 2 \cdot 13 + 2 \cdot 1$; dia2 for $n = 11, \dots, 25$: $0, 2, 2, 0, 0, 0, 2, 4 = 2 \cdot (0, 1, 1, 0, 0, 0, 1, 2)$; rct4 for $n = 9, 17, 19, 21$: $2, 2, 4, 2 = 2 \cdot (1, 1, 2, 1)$ — all in agreement. Two independent implementations (the two agents’ programs) agree on every enumeration they both performed. Every configuration reported here was finally re-checked by an independent script that tests all $\binom{2n}{3}$ triples in exact integer arithmetic and computes the stabilizer explicitly.

4 Results

4.1 Exhaustive enumerations of the defect families

The defect sets were enumerated up to D_4 (one representative per orbit of D_4 acting on defects); for each representative the sub-class was searched exhaustively. Table 1 gives, for odd n , the number of inequivalent 3-cycle defects and the number of pairwise inequivalent configurations found for the two bases; Table 2 gives the two-loop family for even n . Counts marked with

$\geq$ come from sweeps that were still running when this draft was written; the entries will be finalized.

n	3-cycle defects (mod D_4)	C4 base	V2 base	status of the sweep
13	80	5	2	complete
15	140	0	0	complete
17	224	0	1	complete
19	336	0	0	complete
21	480	0	0	complete
33	2240	≥ 1	(0)	complete; final counts being collected
37	3264	≥ 2	0	V2 complete; C4 in progress
39	3876	≥ 1	(0)	half of each base swept
41	4560	—	(0)	half of the V2 base swept; C4 in progress

Table 1: The 3-cycle family (odd n): C4- or V2-orbits plus a directed 3-cycle of half-turn pairs; numbers of pairwise inequivalent configurations. Parenthesised zeros are for partially swept bases (no configuration so far).

n	sub-classes (x, y)	inequivalent configurations
14–22	all	0
24	132	2
26	156	1
28	182	1
36	306	≥ 1 (finding mode; 48 sub-classes searched)

Table 2: The two-loop family (even n): C4-orbits plus one half-turn loop on each long diagonal.

4.2 First configurations with exact half-turn symmetry for $n = 36, 37, 39$

Table 3 lists the new configurations; their coordinates and their encodings in the 90-character format of [3] are given in the Appendix. “First known” refers to the state of the database on 2026-08-11, in which the rot2 cells for $n = 36, 37, 39$ were empty; the $n = 33$ configuration is new but the cell was not empty.

n	family and defect	remark
36	two loops: $(6, 6), (29, 29)$ and $(5, 30), (30, 5)$	first known exact rot2
37	3-cycle $(1, 3), (3, 31), (31, 1)$, C4 base	first known exact rot2
37	3-cycle $(2, 4), (4, 20), (20, 34)$, C4 base	second, inequivalent
39	3-cycle $(4, 8), (8, 20), (20, 34)$, C4 base	first known exact rot2
33	3-cycle $(2, 3), (3, 19), (19, 2)$, C4 base	new (cell not empty)

Table 3: New $2n$ -point configurations with stabilizer exactly $\{1, \rho^2\}$.

4.3 Cost of finding one configuration, and growth

For orientation we report measured costs of finding one $2n$ -point configuration on the $n \times n$ grid with the solver of Section 3, on two consumer machines (Apple M3 laptop, 8 cores; a 12-core x86 server; 8–12 seeds in parallel; wall time to the first configuration): rot4 (even n): $n = 36$:

10–60 s, $n = 40$: 70 s; rct4 (odd n): $n = 41$: 806 s, $n = 43$: about 6.7 core-hours, $n = 45$: none within 3.3 core-hours; rot2: $n = 24$: 10 s, $n = 27$: 137 s. The cost grows by roughly a factor 8–10 per +4 in n for rot4/rct4 and by a factor of about 6 per +2 for rot2, consistent with the exhaustive tree sizes (rot4: $\times 20$ per +4; rot2 and dial: $\times 9$ –10 per +2) divided by the slowly growing numbers of configurations, and consistent with the growth reported for CP-SAT in [4]. Extrapolated to the open sizes 71, 73, 75, 77, ... this gives 10^5 – 10^7 core-hours for our program; the record computations of 2026 (SAT and GPU search on clusters) are of that order or use better tools. Sub-class sweeps of the defect families are cheap because a fixed defect shades a large part of the grid: a sub-class of the 3-cycle family at $n = 37$ –41 is exhausted in seconds to a few minutes.

4.4 Negative results

- A single defect pair off the diagonals is impossible (Corollary 2); the “rot4 except one pair anywhere” family is empty, as our enumerations for $n \leq 27$ had shown before the lemma was found.
- Mixed bases (C4-orbits with at least one V2-orbit, plus a loop for odd n) are empty for all $n \leq 23$ (exhaustive) and no configuration was found by randomized search for $n \leq 33$.
- Warm starts do not work: shifting a known rot4 configuration for $n = 44$ into the 46×46 grid (which preserves all its collinearities) and freeing k of its 22 orbits, no completion exists even for $k = 15$ (exhaustive); configurations of neighbouring sizes appear to be uncorrelated.
- Local search on exactly $2n$ points (min-conflicts with tabu, simulated annealing) fails from $n \approx 12$ –28 on, although it produces large partial configurations easily (e.g. 134 points on the 71×71 grid); belief-propagation decimation without backtracking fails from $n = 8$ on.

5 Reproducibility

The programs, the sub-class lists, the sweep logs and the certified configurations are in the repository <https://github.com/iwasborninbali/saturation> (there.c, kit71/there_twisted_experiment.c, web/stab.py for the exact class and the database encoding, docs/SUBMISSION.md for the configurations). Typical commands: `ALL=1 PAIRS="1,3;3,31;31,1" ./there 37 2` enumerates the sub-class that contains the first $n = 37$ configuration (one configuration, $1.4 \cdot 10^7$ nodes); `PAIRS="6,6;5,30" ./there 36 2` finds the $n = 36$ configuration in about 100 s.

6 Authorship and AI contribution statement

This work was carried out by two autonomous AI agents (Claude Fable 5, Anthropic), running as independent solvers on two machines and communicating through the repository, under the direction of the author of record. The agents wrote the programs, designed and ran the searches, found and proved the balance lemma (independently of each other, in two formulations), verified each other’s results, and drafted this text; the author of record posed the problem, provided the computing environment, made all decisions about scope and publication, and takes responsibility for the content. We estimate that about nine tenths of the technical work was done by the AI systems; we state this plainly because it is true and because current publication policies require disclosure of AI use rather than AI authorship.

Acknowledgements

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References

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- [2] A. Flammenkamp, Progress in the no-three-in-line problem, II, *J. Combin. Theory Ser. A* 81 (1998) 108–113.
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- [4] T. Prellberg, Constraint satisfaction programming for the no-three-in-line problem, arXiv:2602.07751 (2026).
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A The configurations

Rows and columns are numbered $0, \dots, n-1$ from the top-left corner; the encoding is the class character followed by two column characters per row (alphabet 0-9A-Za-z#%&@?!()[]<>{ }=+|-/~^_.:;,. as in [3]).

$n = 36$, **72 points, stabilizer** $\{1, \rho^2\}$. Encoding:
:3NEHFSVZ3FPUE2BNQ8I5GDS08J0TVVXDP9Y1QAM2416BGRZ7MJUHR9COXLT5AKW047KILCW
Rows u : v_1, v_2 (row u has points at columns v_1, v_2):
0: 3,23 1: 14,17 2: 15,28 3: 31,35 4: 3,15 5: 25,30 6: 6,14 7: 2,11
8: 23,26 9: 8,18 10: 5,16 11: 13,28 12: 0,8 13: 19,24 14: 29,34 15: 31,33
16: 13,25 17: 9,34 18: 1,26 19: 10,22 20: 2,4 21: 1,6 22: 11,16 23: 27,35
24: 7,22 25: 19,30 26: 17,27 27: 9,12 28: 24,33 29: 21,29 30: 5,10 31: 20,32
32: 0,4 33: 7,20 34: 18,21 35: 12,32

$n = 37$ (configuration 1), 74 points, stabilizer $\{1, \rho^2\}$. Encoding:
:GJ39EP7VENDZJRSX7P6ZCF28IQ4VWYKQFa06COUa0LAG245WAI SYLO1UBT389H1NDM5TBMRXHK
Rows u : v_1, v_2 (row u has points at columns v_1, v_2):
0: 16,19 1: 3,9 2: 14,25 3: 7,31 4: 14,23 5: 13,35 6: 19,27 7: 28,33
8: 7,25 9: 6,35 10: 12,15 11: 2,8 12: 18,26 13: 4,31 14: 32,34 15: 20,26
16: 15,36 17: 0,6 18: 12,24 19: 30,36 20: 0,21 21: 10,16 22: 2,4 23: 5,32
24: 10,18 25: 28,34 26: 21,24 27: 1,30 28: 11,29 29: 3,8 30: 9,17 31: 1,23
32: 13,22 33: 5,29 34: 11,22 35: 27,33 36: 17,20

$n = 37$ (**configuration 2**), **74 points, stabilizer $\{1, \rho^2\}$** . Encoding:
: FJ7E4PBGK06U5VDZDH9RCF2X4QSTIZQa2X0SEM8a3Y0A1I78AW3YL09RJN1N5V6UCGKPBWMTL
Rows u : v_1, v_2 (row u has points at columns v_1, v_2):
0: 15,19 1: 7,14 2: 4,25 3: 11,16 4: 20,24 5: 6,30 6: 5,31 7: 13,35

8:13,17 9:9,27 10:12,15 11:2,33 12:4,26 13:28,29 14:18,35 15:26,36
 16:2,33 17:0,28 18:14,22 19:8,36 20:3,34 21:0,10 22:1,18 23:7,8
 24:10,32 25:3,34 26:21,24 27:9,27 28:19,23 29:1,23 30:5,31 31:6,30
 32:12,16 33:20,25 34:11,32 35:22,29 36:17,21

$n = 39$, **78 points, stabilizer** $\{1, \rho^2\}$. Encoding:

:CGAWLU7M8CAN1FPZ2K9TXbOPYc7BBL5W3c2E4JIKJY0a0Z6XHRRV04DE159Tia3DNbFSQUGV8H6SMQ

Rows $u : v_1, v_2$ (row u has points at columns v_1, v_2):

0:12,16 1:10,32 2:21,30 3:7,22 4:8,12 5:10,23 6:1,15 7:25,35
 8:2,20 9:9,29 10:33,37 11:24,25 12:34,38 13:7,11 14:11,21 15:5,32
 16:3,38 17:2,14 18:4,19 19:18,20 20:19,34 21:24,36 22:0,35 23:6,33
 24:17,27 25:27,31 26:0,4 27:13,14 28:1,5 29:9,29 30:18,36 31:3,13
 32:23,37 33:15,28 34:26,30 35:16,31 36:8,17 37:6,28 38:22,26

$n = 33$, **66 points, stabilizer** $\{1, \rho^2\}$. Encoding:

:MOAC3H9J6GJOBS9B05PT0VPQHV5UEI2C4SKUEI2R1F671W37RWLN4L8DGQDNFTKM8A

Rows $u : v_1, v_2$ (row u has points at columns v_1, v_2):

0:22,24 1:10,12 2:3,17 3:9,19 4:6,16 5:19,24 6:11,28 7:9,11
 8:0,5 9:25,29 10:0,31 11:25,26 12:17,31 13:5,30 14:14,18 15:2,12
 16:4,28 17:20,30 18:14,18 19:2,27 20:1,15 21:6,7 22:1,32 23:3,7
 24:27,32 25:21,23 26:4,21 27:8,13 28:16,26 29:13,23 30:15,29 31:20,22
 32:8,10